



dropped by almost 50% (from 90 paise per square centimetre to 50 paise per square centimetre for double side PCB). The effect was such that a lot of PCB units operating in India decided to shut and bear significant losses.

“That was the first time when I asked myself if I had made a mistake by leaving my corporate job for entrepreneurship. Those were the toughest five years of my life. We looked at PCB assembly. I do not regret leaving my corporate job, and I do not think I ever will,” says Amrit.

The Sahasra Group, led by Amrit, has an average annual turnover of more than 2.5 billion rupees. It also has a company in the United States. The group also has a unit in Rwanda. The net worth of the group is said to be 1.5 billion rupees. The group is operational in PCBs, memory products, motherboards for data servers, all-in-one PCs, and DVRs for automobiles. The group has recently forayed into the semiconductor packaging arena, and is investing close to 1.5 billion rupees in the same. It has also been selected for PLI for the same by the government of India.

“We will be working on ICs at our new semiconductor facility, and we will be the first in India to do so. The only regret that I have is, I do not have my father and mother to see their son becoming the businessman they always wanted,” he says.

Love at job interview

How Amrit met his wife and the duo started dating is also an interesting story. Amrit’s boss was scheduled to interview candidates for the position

of a secretary. As the day came, Amrit’s boss had to travel outstation for a project and Amrit was told to take these interviews.

“He guided me to test the candidates by giving them dictation. My future-to-be-wife came for an interview. Believe you me, I rejected her because of the way she handled the dictation notes. She wrote telephones in place of tenders and made other mistakes as well,” explains Amrit.

Amrit informed his boss about the interviews. He was not looking to recommend any of the candidates for the position, but his boss told him that if the candidate’s (Amrit’s wife to be) English was good, it was easier for them to help her with the dictations. However, this lady joined L&T with a different team. But who proposed whom?

“She lived very close to where I lived, and one thing led to another. I was the one who proposed first,” says Amrit with a cute smile on his face. The journey from love to marriage wasn’t easy at all. Amrit’s parents were strictly against marrying their son out-of-caste. Amrit and Varsha stood firm on their ground and made it clear that they were marrying each other or not getting married at all.

“My wife has always been on my side. She doesn’t see wealth as a necessity, but she never discouraged me from taking the decision to



4th of July 2006, life almost came a full circle for Amrit with his two sons getting betrothed

quit my job and starting a venture of my own. Yes, I have seen her worried but, despite all that, she encouraged me to start the business. If she had not been in my life, I would not have been able to reach where I am today,” shares a proud Amrit.

He continues, “There used to be days when we used to have rejections worth lakhs of rupees. I would return home sad and dejected and she would sit by my side, cheer me up and assure me that everything will be alright.”

The couple has been blessed with two boys - Varun and Akshay. Varun is currently helping his father at the Sahasra Group whereas Akshay, the elder son, is a writer and a sports journalist, and has also given cricket commentaries for BCCI.

What’s Amrit’s plan for the future?

“I love enjoying single malts. On the official side I would definitely like to see the semiconductor industry grow. We have put in all we had in the semiconductor project. It is a big challenge. My dream is not just to be the first company to do semiconductor and IC packaging but also help India in exporting semiconductors. Besides that, I am also the vice-chairman in the Electronic Sector Skill Council of India (India), and I would like to see skill in the youth of India so that they can make India electronics manufacturing hub of the world,” concludes Amrit. **EFY**

Less known facts about Amrit Manwani

- **A dish that he always requested his mother to prepare** – Lotus stem (Kamal Kakdi)
- **Favourite cuisine** – Chinese
- **Vegetarian/Non-vegetarian** – Mutton is his favourite but had to give up because of health issues
- **Cars/Bikes** – Now cars
- **Car I drive today** – Mercedes
- **Favourite Actress** – Sadhana, Alia Bhatt
- **Favourite Actor** – Amitabh Bachan, Gregory Peck
- **All-time favourite movie** – Deewar
- **A book he can read again and again** – Good Earth, Atlas Shrugged
- **One advice he could give to your younger self** – Don’t follow the beaten path